LIGHTEN YOUR LOAD · AUSTRALIAN PRODUCE GUIDE

Tread Carefully

Tread Carefully doesn't mean avoid. For most of these, peeling, washing or buying from your local farmers markets makes a real difference. If your kids eat one every day, organic is worth considering.



LISTED IN ALPHABETICAL ORDER.



Broccoli & broccolini

Wash well

Lower risk than leafy greens but not negligible. Dense head provides some protection. Wash in running water getting into the florets. Organic worthwhile if eaten daily.



Cucumbers

Peel

Named in AU ATDS monitoring data. Thin edible skin with moderate pesticide use. Sits in the middle of global rankings - not Dirty Dozen but not clean. Peeling removes most surface residues.



Garlic

Buy AU-grown

Most supermarket garlic is imported from China. In 2010–11, China was second only to India for imported food breaching Australian chemical residue limits (Friends of the Earth Melbourne, 2012). Papery skin offers some protection - buy Australian-grown where labelled.



Ginger

Organic

Underground tuber absorbs residual soil pesticides during growth. Almost entirely imported into Australia. Clothianidin detected at high rates in Chinese ginger. Washing is largely ineffective.



Green beans

Wash well

Thin edible pod, high pest pressure. Acephate residues found internationally despite a decade-old ban. AU-specific data is limited but biology is comparable. Frozen green beans are lower risk.



Oranges & citrus

Buy AU-grown

Post-harvest imazalil fungicide (linked to hormone disruption) penetrates the peel into the flesh. Found on ~90% of peeled samples. Imported citrus carries 4× higher levels than AU-grown.



Potatoes

Peel well

90% of samples contain chlorpropham — a post-harvest sprout inhibitor banned in the EU since 2019, still approved in Australia. Concentrated in the skin — peel thoroughly.



Rockmelon

Scrub before cutting

Recent testing found three pesticides on rockmelon, including a systemic neonicotinoid not approved in the EU, and a post-harvest fungicide. The netted rind traps surface residues. Scrub it before cutting so the knife doesn't drag them into the flesh.



Snow peas & sugar snap peas

Wash well

Whole edible pod eaten fresh - no pesticide barrier. Predominantly AU-grown. Only industry-funded residue data available; independent testing is limited.



Tomatoes

Buy local

QLD produce is legally required to be treated with a systemic insecticide dip before interstate transit. Buy locally grown where possible and check origin labelling.



Zucchini

Wash well

Thin edible skin, moderate pesticide use. Similar biology and risk profile to cucumbers. Generally AU-grown with limited independent residue data available.

Where to start

- **Peel potatoes and cucumbers.** Peeling removes most surface residues.
- **Buy local tomatoes.** Queensland tomatoes sent interstate have to be treated with insecticide first. Local ones skip that step.
- **Choose frozen green beans.** Blanching before freezing breaks down residues.
- **Buy Australian garlic and citrus.** Imported versions carry a much higher chemical load.
- **Use ginger every day? Go organic.** It takes up residues from the soil, so washing doesn't help much.



Tip

Get to know your growers. At farmers and growers markets you can ask the person who grew your food how they grow it and what they spray. Crop swaps and community gardens go a step further. Swap your spare zucchini for a neighbour's tomatoes, and you'll know exactly where your food came from.

Sources: FSANZ ATDS · Friends of the Earth Melbourne (2012) · CHOICE · NRS · APVMA · EWG Shopper's Guide (2026) · Guardian AU FOI · Hort Innovation (2025) · Pesticide Action Australia · Full source list →